

W H A L E C L A S S

Circle Time Guide

Everything you need, one page per day

Autumn (1) · The Tree Is Changing

Week 7

Week of Sep 28–30 · Oct 8–9

13 minutes a day

ages 2.5–6

English learners





Week 7 · Week Overview

Autumn (1) · The Tree Is Changing
Print · laminate · ring-bind · hold this all week

5 words they'll own by Friday →

autumn

leaf

red

yellow

windy

Littles (2.5–3)

One word + a gesture is a win: **“Leaf!”** (flutter one hand down to the floor), **“Red!”** (point at something red), **“Windy!”** (whoosh both arms sideways and sway).

Bigs (4–6)

Sentence frames: **“It is autumn.”**

“The leaf is red.”

“The wind blows the leaves down.”

“The tree changed while we were away.”

The week at a glance

MON	Monday 28 September · Autumn	a branch that is only just turning
TUE	Tuesday 29 September · Leaf	a basket of just-fallen leaves, as full as you can carry; yesterday's branch, still standing o...
WED	Wednesday 30 September · Red — and goodbye to the tree	a small red flag and one red maple leaf, side by side in the box; five red things hidden in plain...
THU	Thursday 8 October · Yellow — what changed?	gold ginkgo leaves, picked on your own way in this morning
FRI	Friday 9 October · Windy + the whole song	a paper fan and every leaf the week collected, in one basket; two baskets or hoops labelled re...

2 MIN

Magic Box hook

4 MIN

Teach the words

3 MIN

Song · today's verse

3 MIN

Game · move it

1 MIN

Whisper-shout close

Weekly rituals — use these every single day

Attention grabber: Teacher: **“One, two, three — eyes on me!”** · Kids: **“One, two — eyes on you!”**

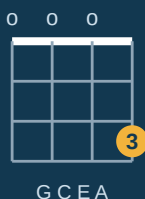
The Magic Box: any box with a lid. Chant it, shake it, sniff it, peek dramatically — the day's key prop lives inside.

The two-tier rule: never make a little produce a sentence, and never let a big get away with one word.

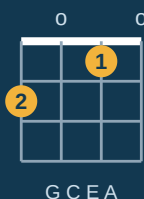
Whisper → shout close: calms them down, then releases them — every single closing.

Teacher-fails-on-purpose: once a day, get it wrong and let them correct you — the correction shout is the loudest language of the day.

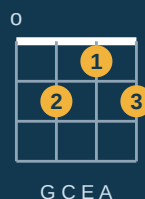
One song a week: same chorus at every circle, one new verse each morning, the whole song on Friday.



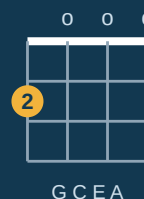
C



F



G7



Am

Uke quick-ref

Strum: Down · Down · Down-Up (“leaves — come — down-now”). Can't manage it yet? Four slow downs per bar works fine — the kids only hear the fun.

The song needs only **C · F · G7 · Am**.

MONDAY

Monday 28 September · Autumn

Today's words: **autumn**

Grab: a branch that is only just turning — mostly green, with two leaves going gold at the tip. **And your phone: you must photograph that branch today.** Thursday's whole lesson depends on the photo. Also: two hoops or two big dishes, a pile of real leaves (half green, half gold), and the autumn character card.

2 MIN MAGIC BOX HOOK

The box is longer than usual today — something is sticking out of the lid. Whole class chants:

EVERYONE "What's in the box? What's in the box?"

Shake it — a dry, papery rustle, nothing else. Sniff the lid: (*eyes closed*) "It smells like... **outside**."

TEACHER "It came off a tree. This morning. And the tree is **changing**." (*lift the branch out slowly and hold it up above their heads so they look up into it*)

Turn it. Two leaves at the tip are gold; the rest are still green. Let them touch one gold leaf each, one at a time.

4 MIN TEACH · AUTUMN

Hold the branch across your two open hands, low, so everyone can see both colours at once.

Green... (*touch a green leaf*)

Green... (*touch another*)

GOLD! (*touch the gold tip — big surprised face*)

It's **autumn**. (*both arms open wide, slow*)

Say the word three times, getting quieter: **autumn**, autumn, autumn. **LITTLES** just say it with you — "**Autumn!**" **BIGS** take the frame: "**It is autumn.**"

Now the photograph. Stand the branch up where everybody can see it, get the whole circle to say "**cheese**" to it, and take the picture in front of them — ceremonially, like it matters, because on Thursday it will. Tell them plainly: "*I am keeping this picture. When we come back after the holiday we will look at it again and see what the tree did without us.*"

Teacher fails: hold up the gold tip, look at it with total confidence and announce "Ah — **green**." Nod. Wait. They will shout you down, and the shouting is the lesson.

Lay the **autumn** card beside the branch on the mat. Say it once, in Chinese — autumn is here — and leave it there. One character a day, no drilling.

3 MIN GAME · GREEN OR GOLD?

"One, two, three — eyes on me!" Two hoops on the floor, well apart. A green leaf in one, a gold leaf in the other — those are the labels. Tip the pile of leaves out in the middle. One child at a time: pick up **one** leaf, hold it high so the circle can see, and run it to the hoop it belongs in. The circle calls the colour as it goes.

EVERYONE "GREEN!" ... "GOLD!"

Go round twice. Then hold up a leaf that is **half and half** and let them argue about it — there is no right answer, and that is exactly the point: it is *changing*.

Real leaves, never paper ones. The dry crackle is half of what they are learning.

1 MIN CLOSE

The week's line, every day. Whisper → normal → shout, with the leaves fluttering down on the last word:

EVERYONE "Red... yellow... WINDY! It's AUTUMN!" (*fingers flutter down, then both arms fly up on AUTUMN*)

Got 3 spare minutes? *Leaf Man* (Lois Ehlert) — every page is real leaves, and they will start seeing faces in the pile outside.

♪ **TODAY'S SONG MOMENT · AUTUMN IS HERE!** chorus → Monday's verse → chorus

CHORUS

C Autumn is here — the **F** leaves come **C** down, (*flutter both hands to the floor*)

F Red and yellow **C** all over the **G7** town! **C** (*big circle arms, point out*)

Am Whoosh goes the wind and **F** away they **C** go, (*whoosh sideways*)

F Round and round **C** and **G7** down be **C** low! (*spin one finger, then crouch*)

MONDAY 28 SEP · AUTUMN

C Summer's packed her bags and gone, (*lift a heavy bag, wave goodbye*)

G7 Autumn's here — **C** put your jumper on! (*pull on a jumper, hug yourself*)

The one song of the week — same chorus at every circle, one new verse each morning, right through the holiday and out the other side. Chords and the full sheet are on the Song tab. The chorus is a finger-play: they will do the actions before they can sing the words.

TUESDAY

Tuesday 29 September · Leaf

Today's words: **leaf** (*autumn comes back every day*)**Grab:** a **basket of just-fallen leaves**, as full as you can carry; yesterday's branch, still standing on the shelf; the leaf card.**2 MIN** MAGIC BOX HOOKToday the box is **heavy and light at the same time**. Let two children lift it. Chant:**EVERYONE** "What's in the box? What's in the box?"

Shake it hard — a huge dry rustle, like rain on a window. Peek in, and make your face enormous.

TEACHER "There are **hundreds**. And they all fell off the tree by themselves." (*stand up, lift the basket high over the middle of the circle and tip it slowly*)Leaves come down over everybody. Let the shrieking run for five whole seconds before you say anything. Then, quietly: "**Leaf!**" — one hand fluttering down to the floor.**4 MIN** TEACH · LEAFEveryone picks up **one** leaf from the floor in front of them. One each, no swapping, and hold it flat on the palm.One little **leaf**... (*hold yours up between two fingers*)Let go... (*drop it, and everyone watches it all the way down*)Down, down, down. (*follow it with your finger*)It landed on **me!** (*catch one on the top of your head*)Now go round the circle: each child holds their leaf up and says one thing about it. **LITTLES** say the word — "**Leaf!**" **BIGS** take a frame: "**My leaf is big.**" "**The leaf is red.**"Then all together: hold the leaf as high as you can reach, and on **three**, everybody lets go at once. Twenty leaves falling in silence is the best three seconds of the week.**Teacher fails:** try to make your leaf fall **upwards**. Throw it at the ceiling, twice, and look genuinely puzzled when it comes back down.The **leaf** card goes down beside yesterday's autumn — The leaves turned yellow. The row is starting to build.**3 MIN** GAME · LEAF, LEAF, DROPEverybody stands up. "You are not children any more. You are **leaves**, and you are still on the branch." Arms up high, fingers spread, completely still.**TEACHER** (*quietly*) "The tree is very still... very still... and then — **WINDY!**"On the word **windy**, every leaf spins slowly down to the floor and goes absolutely still where it lands. Then back up on the branch, and again. Four or five rounds — and make them wait for it, longer each time.The stillness is the game, not the spinning. If they land and stay down for three silent seconds, you have taught self-regulation and the word **windy** in the same breath — and Friday's word is already in the room.**1 MIN** CLOSE

Everyone holds one leaf. Whisper → normal → shout, and throw the leaves up on the last word:

EVERYONE "Red... yellow... WINDY! It's AUTUMN!" (*leaves go up on AUTUMN*)

Now they tidy — every leaf back into the basket, and the basket goes onto Tray 2 for the shape-matching work.

♪ TODAY'S SONG MOMENT · AUTUMN IS HERE! chorus → Tuesday's verse → chorus

CHORUS**C** Autumn is here — the **F** leaves come **C** down, (*flutter both hands to the floor*)**F** Red and yellow **C** all over the **G7** town! **C** (*big circle arms, point out*)**Am** Whoosh goes the wind and **F** away they **C** go, (*whoosh sideways*)**F** Round and round **C** and **G7** down be **C** low! (*spin one finger, then crouch*)**TUESDAY 29 SEP · LEAF****C** One little leaf let go of the tree, (*pinch fingers, then open them*)**G7** Down, down, down — **C** it landed on me! (*flutter down, tap your head*)Sing this one sitting *inside* the fallen leaves. Nobody tidies until after the game — the mess is the material.

WEDNESDAY

Wednesday 30 September · Red — and goodbye to the tree

Today's words: **red** (*the last day before the holiday*)

Grab: a small **red flag** and one **red maple leaf**, side by side in the box; five red things hidden in plain sight round the room; the red card; and Monday's photograph, printed if you can — you will need it on Thursday either way.

National Day holiday · 1–7 October — no circle time. We stop here on Wednesday and come back on **Thursday 8 October**. This is still *one week*: same five words, same song, same four trays on the shelf right through. The hole in the middle is part of the lesson.

2 MIN MAGIC BOX HOOK

Two things in the box today, and they are the same colour. Chant:

EVERYONE "What's in the box? What's in the box?"

Lift out the maple leaf first, high, and turn it slowly. Then the little flag beside it, and hold them together.

TEACHER "Red... and red. One came off a tree. One belongs to the whole country. Tomorrow is **National Day**."

Point at something red on your own clothes. Then they hunt their own: "**Red!**"

4 MIN TEACH · RED

The maple leaf goes round the circle, one child at a time, held up against something of theirs. Same or not the same?

A red, red **leaf**... (*hold it up*)

A red, red **flag**... (*wave it gently*)

Red on my **jumper!** (*point at a child's red thing*)

RED! (*everyone points at anything red at once*)

LITTLES point and name: "**Red!**" **BIGS** take the frame: "**The leaf is red.**" "**I see a red flag.**"

Lay the red leaf beside a green one and a gold one from Tuesday's basket. Three colours, one week, one tree.

Teacher fails: hold the bright red maple leaf up, admire it, and call it **green** — with your whole chest. Say it twice. Let them physically take it off you.

The **red** card joins autumn and leaf on the shelf edge. Happy National Day!

3 MIN GAME · RED HUNT

"One, two, three — eyes on me!" Then: "Find me **five red things** — before the song ends. GO!"

Sing the chorus, slowly, on the ukulele while they scatter. They bring red things back to the middle and pile them up. When the chorus ends, everybody sits, and you count the pile together — out loud, in English and in Chinese.

Last round: everybody holds one red thing, and the red flag goes to whichever child has been waiting most patiently, to wave for the class.

Cap it at five, count it properly, and stop. A hunt that never ends turns into a room-wrecking, and today ends with a ceremony.

1 MIN CLOSE

Standing at the window, flag in one hand. Whisper → normal → shout:

EVERYONE "Red... yellow... WINDY! It's AUTUMN!"

BEFORE YOU GO GOODBYE, TREE — KEEP CHANGING WITHOUT US 🇨🇳

Take the whole class to the window, or outside to the tree itself if you have five spare minutes. Hold up Monday's branch. Then say it, slowly, and mean it:

TEACHER "We are going away for a week. You are not. **Keep changing without us.** When we come back, we are going to look very carefully and find out exactly what you did."

Everybody waves the red flag once. **Goodbye, tree!** Then check the photograph is safe on your phone — that photograph is Thursday's whole lesson.

What stays out over the holiday: all four trays, exactly as they are. The row of Chinese characters (autumn · leaf · red) stays on the shelf edge, and the branch stands beside it. Nothing gets packed away — the room should look like it is still mid-week when they walk back in, because it is.

♪ TODAY'S SONG MOMENT · AUTUMN IS HERE! chorus → Wednesday's verse → chorus

CHORUS

C Autumn is here — the **F** leaves come **C** down, (*flutter both hands to the floor*)

F Red and yellow **C** all over the **G7** town! **C** (*big circle arms, point out*)

Am Whoosh goes the wind and **F** away they **C** go, (*whoosh sideways*)

F Round and round **C** and **G7** down be **C** low! (*spin one finger, then crouch*)

WEDNESDAY 30 SEP · RED

C A red, red flag and a red, red leaf, (*wave the flag, hold up the leaf*)

G7 Goodbye, tree — **C** we'll be back next week! (*big slow wave at the window*)

Sing this one **at the window**, facing the actual tree. It is a goodbye song today, and they should be able to see who they are saying goodbye to.

THURSDAY

Thursday 8 October · Yellow — what changed?

Today's words: **yellow** (*first day back — and Cold Dew*)

Grab: gold ginkgo leaves, picked on your own way in *this morning* — not last week's;
Monday's photograph, on the biggest screen you can find; a jar of **cold, wet grass** for Cold Dew; the yellow card. Two minutes before circle, take them outside to touch the railing: *Is it cool?*

Welcome back. Happy National Day — the class has been away for seven days (1–7 October) and this is the **second half of the same week**. Do not start a new theme. Same words, same song, same trays, same branch on the shelf. Today is the day the hole in the middle pays off — and it is also **Cold Dew**, the third autumn solar term, the morning the dew turns cold to touch.

2 MIN MAGIC BOX HOOK

The box has been sitting on the shelf, shut, for a week. Say so. Chant:

EVERYONE "What's in the box? What's in the box?"

Shake it — a rustle, and something sloshes. Peek, and go very still.

TEACHER (*whisper*) "These were not this colour when you left." (*lift out a handful of gold ginkgo leaves and let them fall through your fingers*)

Then the jar of cold wet grass. Everyone touches it. "**Cold!**" That is **Cold Dew** — Cold Dew is here — the dew turns cold.

4 MIN TEACH · YELLOW — AND WHAT CHANGED?

This is the big one. Hold Monday's **photograph** up in one hand and the real branch in the other, right next to each other, and say nothing at all for five seconds.

We went away... (*walk two fingers off to one side*)
 and the tree turned **GOLD**. (*hold up a ginkgo leaf, high*)
 Yellow, yellow — (*everyone points at the gold*)
 look, behold! (*hands open wide*)

Now round the circle: each child names **one thing** that is different between the photograph and the branch. **LITTLES** point at the gold and say the word — "**Yellow!**" **BIGS** take the full frame: "**The tree changed while we were away.**" "**The leaf is yellow now.**"

Then the honest part, said plainly: "*Nobody watched it. It did it anyway.*" Beijing's ginkgo trees all turned at once while they were on holiday, and every single child walked past it.

Teacher fails: look from the photo to the branch and back, frown, and announce "Hmm. Exactly the same." Hold your ground for a good long moment.

The **yellow** card joins autumn · leaf · red on the shelf edge. Ask what colour the trees outside their own homes are — every answer is right and every answer is evidence.

3 MIN GAME · WHAT CHANGED?

Monday's photograph propped up in the middle of the circle; the real branch lying beside it; the gold ginkgo leaves in a pile.

One child at a time comes into the middle, points at **one** difference and names it. The circle answers together: "**It CHANGED!**" Nobody may repeat somebody else's difference — which forces them to look properly.

Second round, harder and quieter: everyone shuts their eyes, you move or turn **one** thing on the mat, and they open them and find it. Three times.

This is the sensorial memory work the whole week was built around, and the holiday is what made it possible. Take every answer, even a wrong one — "the pot moved" counts, they are looking.

1 MIN CLOSE

A gold leaf in every hand. Whisper → normal → shout:

EVERYONE "Red... yellow... WINDY! It's AUTUMN!" (*gold leaves fly up on AUTUMN*)

Got 3 spare minutes? *Fletcher and the Falling Leaves* (Julia Rawlinson) — a small fox worries about a tree losing its leaves. Read it today, of all days.

♪ TODAY'S SONG MOMENT · AUTUMN IS HERE! chorus → Thursday's verse → chorus

CHORUS

C Autumn is here — the **F** leaves come **C** down, (*flutter both hands to the floor*)

F Red and yellow **C** all over the **G7** town! **C** (*big circle arms, point out*)

Am Whoosh goes the wind and **F** away they **C** go, (*whoosh sideways*)

F Round and round **C** and **G7** down be **C** low! (*spin one finger, then crouch*)

THURSDAY 8 OCT · YELLOW

Am We went away and the tree turned gold, (*walk fingers away, arms up like branches*)

G7 Yellow, yellow — **C** look, behold! (*point, then open both hands*)

This verse starts on **Am** — the one darker chord in the song, and it lands on the day they come back to a changed tree. Slow right down for it.

FRIDAY

Friday 9 October · Windy + the whole song

Today's words: **windy** (+ all five, all week, one last time)

Grab: a **paper fan** and every leaf the week collected, in one basket; two baskets or hoops labelled **red** and **yellow**; the wind card; the star awards (page 17), signed and ready.

2 MIN MAGIC BOX HOOK

Last box of the week, and it is completely silent. Chant:

EVERYONE "What's in the box? What's in the box?"

Shake it. Nothing. Shake it harder. Still nothing. Look worried.

TEACHER "It's **empty**... no, wait." (*lift out the folded paper fan, open it with one snap, and fan the whole front row's hair*)Whoosh both arms sideways and sway. "**Windy!**"**4 MIN** TEACH · WINDY

Tip the week's whole basket of leaves onto the mat in one heap. Then kneel down and fan it, hard.

The windy, windy **wind**... (*fan, big sweeps*)goes whoosh and blow! (*everyone whooshes with you*)And all the leaves... (*hands high*)let go, LET GO! (*hands open, everything flutters*)The fan goes round the circle, one child at a time: three fans each, and the rest of the class makes the wind sound. **LITTLES**say the word with the whoosh — "**Windy!**" **BIGS** take the frame: "**The wind blows the leaves down.**"

Then blow with your mouths instead: one big class breath, all together, on three. The leaves barely move. Try the fan again.

Which is stronger? That is a real question with a real answer, and they can see it.

Teacher fails: fan yourself elegantly and wonder aloud why the leaves are not moving. Point the fan at your own face for a good ten seconds before somebody turns your wrist round.The **wind** card completes the row: **autumn · leaf · red · yellow · wind**. Read it left to right with them once — that row is the week, and it is also your display.**3 MIN** GAME · RED BASKET, YELLOW BASKET

Two baskets, far apart. One leaf at a time, one child at a time: pick it up, hold it high, name the colour, run it to the right basket. The circle calls the colour with them.

EVERYONE "RED!" ... "YELLOW!"

Go until the mat is clear. Then count both baskets out loud — which one won? Fan the winner over the floor and watch it all come down again, and let them groan.

Then the awards: one star each, name read out, on the spot. And the leaf worksheets (page 16) go home with them.

1 MIN CLOSE

Everyone holding a leaf, fan in the middle. Whisper → normal → biggest shout of the week:

EVERYONE "Red... yellow... WINDY! It's AUTUMN!" (*the whole basket goes up on AUTUMN*)

Next week we stay in autumn — the tree finishes giving its leaves away, and the field gives us food.

♪ **TODAY'S SONG MOMENT · AUTUMN IS HERE!** Friday's verse, then the WHOLE song, top to bottom**CHORUS****C** Autumn is here — the **F** leaves come **C** down, (*flutter both hands to the floor*)**F** Red and yellow **C** all over the **G7** town! **C** (*big circle arms, point out*)**Am** Whoosh goes the wind and **F** away they **C** go, (*whoosh sideways*)**F** Round and round **C** and **G7** down be **C** low! (*spin one finger, then crouch*)**FRIDAY 9 OCT · WINDY****C** The windy, windy wind goes whoosh and blow, (*big fanning sweeps*)**G7** And all the leaves **C** let go, let go! (*hands high, then open*)

This run-through IS the week's review. Do not add a second review activity — five verses in order is the five words in order, and they will sing it without knowing they are being assessed. Watch for the two-year-olds doing all four chorus actions: that is a pass.

★ Autumn Is Here!

Week 7 theme song
C (0003) · F (2010) · G7 (0212) · Am (2000)

The one song of the week — sung at every circle, on both sides of the holiday. Same chorus daily, one new verse each morning, full song on Friday.

CHORUS — SING IT EVERY SINGLE DAY

- C** Autumn is here — the **F** leaves come **C** down, *(flutter both hands to the floor)*
F Red and yellow **C** all over the **G7** town! **C** *(big circle arms, point out)*
Am Whoosh goes the wind and **F** away they **C** go, *(whoosh sideways)*
F Round and round **C** and **G7** down be **C** low! *(spin one finger, then crouch)*

MONDAY 28 SEP · AUTUMN

- C** Summer's packed her bags and gone, *(lift a heavy bag, wave goodbye)*
G7 Autumn's here — **C** put your jumper on! *(pull on a jumper, hug yourself)*

TUESDAY 29 SEP · LEAF

- C** One little leaf let go of the tree, *(pinch fingers, then open them)*
G7 Down, down, down — **C** it landed on me! *(flutter down, tap your head)*

WEDNESDAY 30 SEP · RED

- C** A red, red flag and a red, red leaf, *(wave the flag, hold up the leaf)*
G7 Goodbye, tree — **C** we'll be back next week! *(big slow wave at the window)*

THURSDAY 8 OCT · YELLOW

- Am** We went away and the tree turned gold, *(walk fingers away, arms up like branches)*
G7 Yellow, yellow — **C** look, behold! *(point, then open both hands)*

FRIDAY 9 OCT · WINDY

- C** The windy, windy wind goes whoosh and blow, *(big fanning sweeps)*
G7 And all the leaves **C** let go, let go! *(hands high, then open)*

Strum: Down · Down · Down-Up (“leaves — come — down-now”).

Can't manage it yet? Four slow downs per bar works fine — the kids only hear the fun.

Practice this loop for five minutes tonight: **C** (4 strums) → **F** (4 strums) → **C** → **G7** → **C**. Add **Am** last: it is one finger on the same string as F, so slide from Am to F and back until it stops feeling like a change. That is the entire song — and four of the five verses are only C and G7. If your fingers get stuck, put the uke down and do the finger-play instead: the class will not notice, and the actions carry the meaning either way.